

Starting from Lecture 8, the General Paper Department will be sharing a curated selection of articles and editorials to keep you abreast of current global and local issues. This initiative is designed to broaden your perspectives and deepen your critical analysis across various themes. We kick things off this week with "The Two Es": Education and Equality.

I: Education

The following are some news articles and commentaries delving into some modern-day anxieties and challenges faced by schools, teachers and students. Click on the hyperlinks to find out more.

Note: Should you have a problem accessing any article via its link, look the title of the article up in your web browser.

1. [Channel News Asia: "Selling success or exploiting anxiety? Time to take a hard look at Singapore's tuition industry"](#)

This piece examines the aggressive marketing tactics used by Singapore's private tuition centres, which often prey on parental fears of academic failure. It highlights the ethical debate surrounding these fear-mongering strategies and the ongoing push for stricter industry regulations to protect students' well-being.

2. [Channel News Asia: "What the demographic 'time bomb' spells for S'pore's education system"](#)

This article explores the profound impact of Singapore's declining birth rates and shrinking student cohorts on its educational landscape. It details how these demographic shifts are leading to record-low enrollments, prompting structural changes such as widespread school mergers and discussions about reducing class sizes.

3. [The Guardian: "Pupils fear AI is eroding their ability to study, research finds"](#)

This report discusses recent research revealing that while a vast majority of students regularly use artificial intelligence, they are increasingly concerned about its long-term personal effects. Many pupils fear that relying on AI makes assignments too easy, ultimately stunting their creativity and preventing the development of essential study skills.

4. [The Conversation: "The greatest risk of AI in higher education isn't cheating"](#)

Following up on the student anxieties highlighted in Article 3, this piece argues that the true danger of artificial intelligence is the fundamental erosion of the learning process itself. It warns that by automating knowledge production, AI threatens to short-circuit students' intellectual development, and undermine the cultivation of human judgement, mentorship and expertise.

5. [Channel News Asia: "Let's stop overstating the value of a university degree beyond your first job"](#)

This commentary challenges the traditional premium placed on university qualifications, arguing that practical skills, adaptability, and workplace experience matter far more in the long run. It urges employers and job seekers alike to move beyond rigid academic biases and recognise the value of alternative learning pathways in a rapidly changing economy.

Food for Thought

1. The modern workforce increasingly demands practical skills, workplace experience and adaptability over rigid academic qualifications (Article 5). However, the foundational critical thinking required to be adaptable is actively being stunted by an over-reliance on AI shortcuts (Articles 3 & 4) and overshadowed by rote, examination-focused tuition (Article 1). **How can students develop the very agility the economy demands when their educational journey is defined by outsourced thinking and high-stakes memorisation?**
2. Given the unavoidable "demographic time bomb" shrinking classroom sizes (Article 2) and the realisation that university degrees do not guarantee lifelong career success (Article 5), **should governments and parents radically redirect the billions of dollars currently spent on private tuition (Article 1) and traditional higher education toward community-building, AI-literacy, and continuous, skill-based adult learning?**

II: Equality, Rights and Freedoms

The following are some recently published news articles and commentaries delving into some of today's most controversial issues surrounding equality, rights and freedoms. Click on the hyperlinks to find out more.

1. [The Guardian: "What is the DEI rollback and where will it spread next?"](#)

Driven by recent US executive orders and conservative legal pressure, major multinational corporations like Google, Amazon and Walmart are rapidly dismantling their diversity, equity and inclusion programmes, sparking concerns about a broader global retreat from workplace equality.

2. [*The Guardian: "The Guardian view on gen Z: young men hold startling views about women – inequality may be to blame"*](#)

A disturbing trend has emerged in recent years: a significant portion of Generation Z men hold highly regressive views on women's rights and gender roles, creating a massive ideological divide within the youngest voting bloc.

3. [*The Guardian: "Human rights experts raise concerns over Olympics transgender women athlete ban"*](#)

There was an intense backlash from over 100 human rights and scientific groups against the International Olympic Committee's (IOC) new 2026 guidelines. The IOC mandated blanket bans on transgender women and implemented mandatory genetic sex tests for all female athletes.

4. [*The Guardian: "UK officials use AI to decide on issues from benefits to marriage licences"*](#)

UK government departments and police forces are increasingly using poorly regulated and potentially biased artificial intelligence tools to make life-changing decisions regarding welfare, immigration and criminal justice, sparking concerns over discrimination and a lack of transparency.

Food for Thought

1. Look across all four articles and **categorise the different types of barriers to equality presented** (for example, political/legal, cultural, psychological, scientific/technological et cetera). **Which of these barriers do you believe is the most deeply entrenched and difficult to overcome?**

2. **Is backlash to efforts promoting equality an inevitable consequence of social progress, or is it a symptom of a flawed strategy?**

Consider whether equality is being perceived as a "zero-sum game" (where one group's gain is viewed as another's loss) and how advocates can address the anxieties of those who resist change.

3. **How should society balance the human right to individual identity and inclusion with its endeavour to preserve traditional values, beliefs and norms?**